



# How to advertise travel

Ogilvy & Mather of New York has created over \$130-million worth of travel advertising. Here, with the dogmatism of brevity, are some things we've learned about selling travel.

**E**VERY TRAVEL product at Ogilvy & Mather is carefully "positioned" before the creative work begins. This is a vital first step.

In positioning a travel product or destination, we have found that research is essential.

A capsule case history: research for KLM revealed that travelers who hadn't been to Amsterdam, KLM's gateway city, thought the city was lacking in "things to do."

So, we positioned Amsterdam as a lively, surprising destination for U.S. travelers. Our "Surprising Amsterdam" campaign featured the vast variety of attractions in KLM's hometown (see advertisement at right).

Within two years, Amsterdam became the fourth most popular tourist city in Europe (after London, Paris and Rome). Within five years, U.S. air traffic to the Netherlands was up 100 percent.

Correct positioning is half the battle. The rest is technique. Here are 22 proven techniques for advertising and selling travel.

## How to write travel copy that sells

**1. Spotlight the "unique differences."** People travel to soak up new experiences. Good copy creates an atmosphere that whets the reader's appetite for adventure.

Research conducted for the United States Travel Service revealed what prospective travelers to the U.S. really want to see. They aren't very interested in beaches and mountains, for example. They have similar attractions at home. They want to see Manhattan, Niagara Falls, Cowboys and Indians, San Francisco, the Grand Canyon—spectacles found "Only in America." This is now the theme of our worldwide United States Travel Service campaign.

**2. Facts are far better than generalities.** Vacations are precious. Prospective travelers want to be sure they're going to get their money's worth. Specific facts can convince them.

A recent Ogilvy & Mather advertisement for American Express was headlined: "What will your trip to Europe really cost this summer?" It was packed with specifics. It gave hotel prices and compared them with 1971 prices. It listed new transatlantic group air fares and the per-person increase over last year.

**3. Give your advertising a big idea.** Take a look at the travel sections of Sunday newspapers. Some have as many as 25 pages of travel advertising. If your advertisement isn't based on an idea that can stand out from the crowd, you won't have a chance.

Note: Five years ago, Ogilvy & Mather created "The New Money" campaign for the American Express Card. This idea was so sweeping in concept that even the design and color of the Card were changed. Today, The Money Card is used by 4,000,000 traveling Americans.

**4. Don't shy away from long copy.** One of our recent advertisements for Cunard had 1096 words. The first time it ran it attracted enough prospects to pay for itself four times in direct sales.

**5. Copy should allay anxiety about going to a strange place.** While most travelers relish the idea of experiencing a totally new destination, the anticipation may be mixed with a vague feeling of unease.

A study by Louis Harris & Associates showed that travelers are anxious about many things—

from the quality of the drinking water to "how much should I tip?"

Good advertising can help to overcome uncertainties and doubts that often trouble travelers.

**6. Use research to test provocative new ideas.** Two years ago, David Ogilvy had an idea for a campaign to increase U.S. travel to France. All of the headlines would be in French with English subtitles. Everybody except David Ogilvy thought it was a terrible idea. Research showed that it increased readership by 24 percent.

**7. Give your product a first-class ticket.** It pays to give your product an image of quality. If your advertising looks cheap or ugly, few consumers will want to travel to your destination—or fly on your airline.

**8. "Newsbreak" advertising can make news of its own.** Last

summer, many Americans abroad were unable to exchange their dollars for foreign money because of the currency crisis.

Ogilvy & Mather prepared an advertisement with this headline: "How American Express protects its clients abroad."

The advertisement was written, approved, set in type, and sent to the papers in 24 hours.

That same week, Ogilvy & Mather people in London and Paris filmed man-in-the-street interviews about the international money crisis. The commercials were on the air in less than two weeks.

**9. Bargains are still irresistible.** By Labor Day 1971, the two October transatlantic crossings of the QE2 were only half booked. In mid-September, an Ogilvy & Mather advertisement for Cunard made this offer: "Sail to Europe regular fare—Sail home free." Within eight days, both round-trip crossings were sold out.

## How to generate more coupon returns

**10. Make your coupon the hero.** Most direct response experts put the coupon at the base of the ad. Ogilvy & Mather had found that prominence is all important. Recently, we moved the coupon to the top of four different American Express Travel advertisements. Returns tripled.

**11. Make the coupon a miniature advertisement.** Include an illustration of your literature. Repeat salient sales facts: "Please send me your free 226-page guide to Europe, with full details of 85 differ-

### Only in America



Show what's different. Our campaign for the United States Travel Service features unique U.S. attractions, like the Manhattan skyline.

### The travel accounts we serve:

|                  |                |
|------------------|----------------|
| AMERICAN EXPRESS | UNITED STATES  |
| BRITISH TOURIST  | TRAVEL SERVICE |
| AUTHORITY        | IN THE U.K.:   |
| CUNARD           | AIR CANADA     |
| KLM ROYAL DUTCH  | IN GERMANY:    |
| AIRLINES         | LUFTHANSA      |
| P&O LINES        |                |

ent tours." Many people read only the coupon.

**12. Don't scorn that grand old word—"free."** Some copywriters eschew this word because it's old hat. Pity. It pulls.

**13. Go the whole hog.** If you really want response, devote your whole advertisement to a description of what you're offering. Give prospects detailed information of what they're getting. Example: "Page 7—a handy list of indispensable foreign phrases."

**14. Repeat your winners.** Many excellent coupon-pulling ads are discarded too soon. When you find an advertisement that generates response, run it until it stops pulling.

Important qualifier: Ogilvy & Mather has found that headlines can lose their stopping power when repeated frequently in newspaper travel sections. Often, a new headline can boost returns significantly.

## Travel layouts: what we've learned

**15. Avoid "addy" layouts.** Ogilvy & Mather has had more success with editorial layouts. Good mag-



Cunard announces round-trip vacations at one-way prices. From \$389



Cunard Queen Elizabeth 2 The Great Oceanic World

"Sold out." This advertisement helped sell out the QE2. Bargains are still irresistible.

See point #9.

azine and newspaper editors know what appeals to their readers. Steal some of their secrets.

**16. Photograph the natives, not the tourists.** Nobody's going to travel thousands of miles to gaze at fellow tourists. One of our KLM advertisements pictured eighty-six natives of Amsterdam. Starch ranked it among the best-read advertisements of the year.

**17. Caption your photographs.** Almost twice as many people read captions as read body copy. Captions should contain meaty information that sells.

## TV techniques

**18. Give your commercials a burr of singularity.** The average travel prospect is exposed to about 15,000 television commercials a year. Most

of them register on her mind with the impact of a flea hitting an elephant.

One of our TV commercials for KLM showed an amphibious touring Amsterdam by water. This burr not only increased the memorability of the commercial but also drew attention to one of the city's greatest attractions—its waterways and canals.

## How American Express protects its clients abroad.

American Express Travelers Cheques, Cards and other financial paper are being honored—without limit—at a network of over 1000 offices throughout the world.



American Express

Fast action. This full-page advertisement was written, approved and produced within 24 hours.

**19. Let your pictures do the talking.** Far better to make your point visually than verbally. What you show is more important than what you say.

**20. Relevant sound effects.** They can create mental pictures of a beautiful beach or a tropical forest. One sound is worth a dozen adjectives.

## Direct mail & sales literature

**21. Test direct mail against other media—it could surprise you.** When your product is well known, direct mail can outpull print and broadcast media on a cost-per-return basis. Example: a test for one of our clients showed that direct mail was four times more efficient than magazines, seven times more efficient than television.

**22. Make your sales literature work as hard as your media advertising.** Your literature should enlarge the story you tell in your media advertising. An account supervisor at Ogilvy & Mather wrote a 224-page book for KLM: "Fun Lover's Guide to Surprising Amsterdam." It features 101 places to eat, drink and be entertained—and lists 1,600 prices.

Ogilvy & Mather now has 46 offices in 24 countries.

|           |           |                |
|-----------|-----------|----------------|
| ARGENTINA | GERMANY   | MEXICO         |
| AUSTRALIA | HOLLAND   | NEW ZEALAND    |
| AUSTRIA   | HONG KONG | NIGERIA        |
| BELGIUM   | INDIA     | SINGAPORE      |
| BRAZIL    | INDONESIA | SOUTH AFRICA   |
| CANADA    | ITALY     | UNITED KINGDOM |
| COLOMBIA  | KENYA     | UNITED STATES  |
| FRANCE    | MALAYSIA  | VENEZUELA      |

Ogilvy & Mather has a strong point-of-view about travel advertising. If you would like to know more about that viewpoint—and how it could be applied to specific travel marketing problems, write Ogilvy & Mather, 2 East 48th Street, New York, N.Y. 10017.

**Ogilvy & Mather**  
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How to Advertise Travel Ad by David Ogilvy  
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